

Seagate 3TB

Seagate plans to release the 3TB hard disk drive sometime this year

Isadora!

Linux Mint 9, codenamed Isadora was launched this month

has A2DP support for Bluetooth headsets. It uses Internet Explorer 6 for browsing, that has copy-paste functionality and is nearly sufficient, but importantly lacks tab support.

On the whole, with the smallish and low colour screen, the phone is not very beautiful to look at, a fact made worse by the boring Windows Mobile interface. The main menu is also badly designed, with only six pixelated icons fitting per screen, making you scroll interminably to locate what you are looking for at the bottom of the menu. While the 3.2MP camera is decent enough for point-and-shoot purposes, its limited 1.6x digital zoom and lack of flash is apparent. On the whole the full email and Push Email support is adequate, though Exchange support would have been welcome.

The phone on the whole has decent build quality, but the keys require some hard pressing, and the 62 millimetre breadth puts it at the limit of easy fitting on a palm. With regards to call clarity, the LG GW550 doesn't score too well on the earpiece or loudspeaker's volume, but it has pretty exceptional hands-free volume and clarity. The loudspeaker and back panel is supposedly enhanced to deal with ambient noise, but it's not too effective. The dual speakers are pretty good for listening to music though.

Verdict

If you are looking for good quality, full-QWERTY phone with 3G and Wi-Fi support, and good productivity tools like Office Mobile and Push Email, as well as instant messaging support, all at a price point lower than a Nokia E72 or E71, then the LG GW550 is for you. However, the dated OS and interface, small screen, and

flash-less camera are trade-offs you'll have to take into account. Whatever its drawbacks though, the device is certainly a decent buy.

High-end smartphones

(18,001 to 25,000)

While this price category is nearly as competitive as the last, we decided to pick some of the most exceptional phones in the segment, based on their popularity, stunning looks, productivity options, and all-rounder functionalities. Brands included here are Blackberry, Garmin Asus, LG, and Nokia.

Garmin Asus Nuvifone M10

The Garmin-Asus Nuvifone M10 is priced at Rs. 19,990, and is a beautifully built navigator phone which runs on Windows Mobile 6.5.3 Professional. At first glance, what is immediately apparent is the stunning clarity and brightness of the Nuvifone M10's 3.5-inch OLED WVGA resistive touchscreen.

The 3D Desktop Manager is quite useful, allowing you to



Garmin Asus Nuvifone M10

close any programs that are running in the background by holding the Windows key.

The 5MP camera takes some decent images, but the lack of flash is felt in low-light. Video recording is of average quality. The 4GB built-in memory is particularly useful here. The phone is quite fast, with a 600MHz CPU along with adequate memory: 512MB ROM and RAM. The call clarity was superb, though the loudspeaker had some problems with low volume output. Music playback was excellent, both on loudspeaker and good quality bundled earphones. As for video playback quality, the phone played mp4 files without a hitch, though its 65K colour limitation (because of Windows Mobile 6.5.3, not the screen) did cause some colour banding.

While the OLED touchscreen is beautiful, it is not very responsive, requiring some hard taps and repetition at times. It is manageable once you become used to the pressure required, though neither the stylus nor finger seem perfectly supported. As for text-input, the on-screen keyboard is sensitive enough, but the keys are rather small and close together unless you use a stylus - even in landscape mode. The auto-rotate function of the device is bit buggy, with near random UI rotations or none at all.

Verdict

It performed well in all our tests, from call clarity to GPS accuracy, and its NAVTEQ Maps were very detailed. Loca-

tion based services were useful, and the interface is easily customisable. It calls All in all, if you are looking for a GPS-focussed feature-rich 3G smartphone, the Nuvifone M10 will fit your bill. The bright screen and great GPS functions are the phone's advantages, while the buggy auto-rotate, the flash-less camera, and the erratic touchscreen are the phone's biggest failings, all of which are not expected at the Rs. 19,990 price point. However, if you are simply looking for a large touchscreen navigator phone, go for the Nokia 5800 Xpress Music instead.

LG BL40 Chocolate

Definitely a one-of-a-kind phone, the LG BL40 Chocolate and its slim, extra long candy-bar body will attract attention. Running on LG's proprietary S-Class UI, the Chocolate has a 4.01-inch "panoramic display" screen with a cinematic 21:9 aspect ratio. The phone has a super-bright screen, support for the DivX/XviD video format, and features like Dolby mobile sound, and TV-out. The HD LCD screen's 345 x 800 resolution is rated as Real WVGA



LG BL40 Chocolate

by LG, and offers surprisingly good legibility in sunlight.

The build quality of the BL40 Chocolate is certainly top-notch, though its solid glossy black plastic body and large screen does pick up some scratches and smudges. Buttons are well placed and responsive, and the phone, even with its long form factor, does fit in the average sized pocket. The microUSB has got